TWINS ARE BIRDS #1

Why Are Twins Birds?

Why is Nike losing the streets?

THE PROBLEM #4

Why is Nike losing the streets?

80 year old Walt Stack made a smart move leaving his teeth in his locker - but as he briskly waved at the motorists whilst jogging across a very golden looking golden gate bridge back in 1988 did he know what he had just done by *Just Doing It*?

Maybe after, but certainly in the Octogenarian joggers wake was woken a juggernaut of icons; Jordan, Tupac, Wu-Tang Clan, Lil Wayne, Drake - others Walt may not have heard of.

Such was the force and cultural velocity of Nike's ascendance that it simultaneously created and conquered entire sartorial territories - it claimed the streets - and became the de-facto uniform and unchosen choice of entire generations.

Today Nike, clearly exhausted by those years at the top, plaintively asks Why Do It? Or to put it another way - Why Bother?

In 2026 that's a good question - but here is a more interesting one. How can a brand that so thoroughly owns the imagination of the streets start to lose its grip?

Why are twins birds?

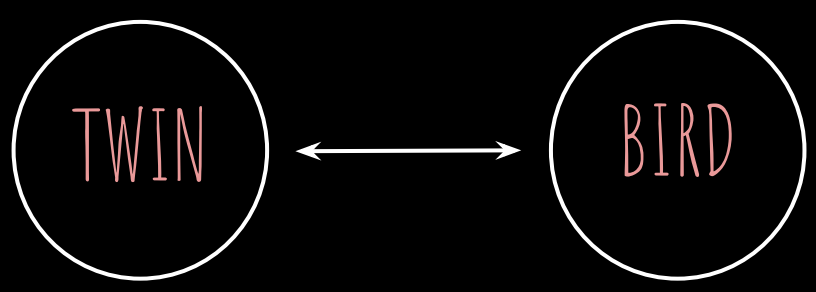
"When I asked a Nuer whether adult twins would be buried like other people he replied no, of course not, they are birds and their souls go up into the air."

If the Nuer used to say that Twins are birds, then surely they meant it as a metaphor or a figure of speech?

But if that was true then why were twins not allowed to eat other birds, or even the eggs of birds? And why were they buried in the forks of trees or on raised platforms so that their souls could be closer to the sky?

What if we take the idea seriously?

What if Twins ARE birds - what would that mean?



Twins are birds

"Though Nuer do not mistake ideal relations for real ones, an ideal equivalence is nonetheless true for them [...] things are not just what they appear to be but as they are conceived of in relation to God."

The Nuer didn't think twins had beaks or feathers or that they laid eggs. They treated them as ordinary people, who had a special relationship to birds that was *in addition* to their status as people.

That status was a shared kindred of the spirit. Because of the unusual nature of their birth twins ***come from the above*** in the same way that birds ***inhabit the above.***

The above is the realm of the divine and so twins and birds are close to God in a way that ordinary people are not.

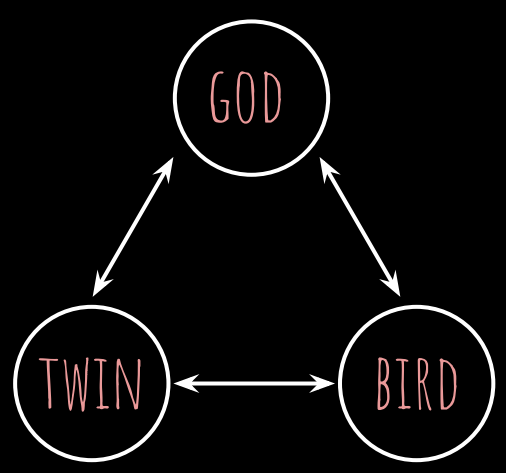
Through their relationship to God, twins are closer to birds than they are to other people. Twins are birds.

Why are twins birds?

"Statements that something is something else should not be taken as matter-of-fact statements [...] They are statements, not that A is B, but that A and B have something in common in relation to C."

When the Nuer were talking about the relationship between twins and birds, they were also talking about the relationship that twins and birds shared with God. Not a two way relationship, but a three way relationship - God, Bird, Twin.

Twins and Birds belong to a wider ecosystem of ideas and categories and relationships - by uncovering that hidden third category of God - the statement that twins are birds makes sense.



Twins are birds

"God is likened to wind and air,not because he is air or wind, but because he is like them in being invisible and everywhere."

- E,E Evans Pritchard, 1956

Terracotta statuette of woman with bird face, Late Cypriot, 1450-1200 BCE

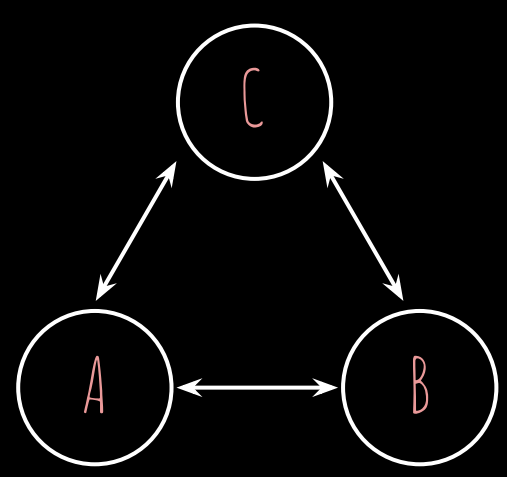
The Hidden Third: From A to B to C.

The way things relate to each other makes perfect sense to the people who imagine those relationships. Cat & Dog. Car & Bike. Things that belong together. A & B.

But A & B are empty without the qualities they share that brings them together. And those qualities are never obvious. For Cat & Dog the connection could be Pet but it could also be Allergen or Phobia or Lunch.

The hidden third category is often missed because both the person asking the questions and the person answering them assume it's obvious or fixed in one place.

But C - the hidden third - is the unlock to understanding how people think.

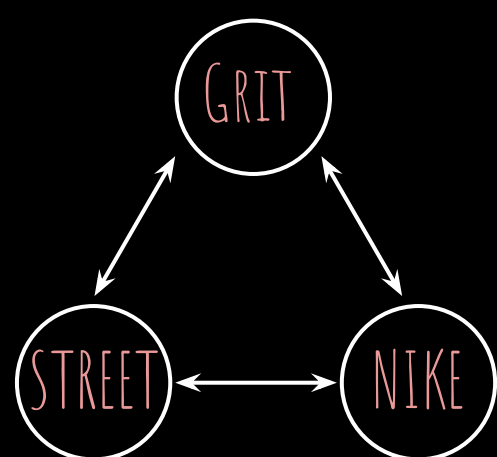


THE SOLUTION

Why is Nike losing the streets?

Nike & Street. A & B. Twin & Bird. Obvious and self apparent unless you are not from the *Banlieue* - in which case finding the hidden third is the key to unlocking the qualities of the relationship between Nike and the Street.

Like Twins & Birds, Nike & Street share a spirit. For the *Banlieue* the hidden third is Grit - not just Grit as hard work, but Grit as the struggle for recognition. Recognition that people like them are worthy of the attention and success and blood and victory that belongs to hip-hop artists, basketball players and the streets alike. Through Just Do It Nike was built on the self evidence of the struggle - asking 'Why Do It?' even once - severs that connection at the root.



AFTERWORD

Evans Pritchard, and the warts and all of Anthropology's colonial past.

'Twins are birds' is the lyricism of the human mind at work. Understanding the mechanisms that sit behind it - and what they mean for how we relate to the social world around us - is equally poetic and wonderful. But it doesn't come without some pretty heavy baggage.

Writing about The Nuer in Southern Sudan is about as colonial as it comes - there is a ring of 'boys own adventure' that is uncomfortably close and uncomfortably true.

Evans Pritchard's observations of the Nuer were sponsored by an empire who wanted to control them, and they suffered greatly under the heel of the British. Evans Pritchard was more than just a colonial spy - his work carries a genuine respect for the Nuer - but it sits uneasily with the project he was contributing to.

What we do with this comes with the territory of Anthropology - the ideas themselves have something important to say - but are they impossibly tainted by the context in which they were created?

Twins are birds

Thanks for reading

Read some more

Nuer Religion - E.E. Evans Pritchard, 1956

Witchcraft, Oracles and Magic Amongst the Azande - E.E. Evans Pritchard, 1937

The Social System - Talcott Parsons, 1951

Metaphors we Live By - George Lakoff, 1980

Read more Twins are birds

https://jimmott-collab.github.io/twins-are-birds/